

Michael Jacobs

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CURRENT EMPLOYMENT

Postdoctoral Researcher, Public Policy Group, ETH Zurich, Switzerland 2025–2028
Postdoctoral researcher on the *Swiss National Science Foundation*-funded project “Improving the Quality of Online Public Discourse”. Responsible for overseeing, coordinating, and supporting the group’s project, including study design, data collection, field protocols, data analysis plans, drafting manuscripts and disseminating results to academics, policy makers and the public.

EDUCATION

University College London 2021–2025
PhD in Political Science, awarded September 2025
Thesis: “*Better to be Maligned than Ignored? The Use of (Disruptive) Protest to Shape Public Discourse and Public Opinion*”
Supervision: Prof. Ben Lauderdale, Dr Katerina Tertychnaya & Dr Jack Blumenau

London School of Economics and Political Science 2017–2018
MSc, Political Science and Political Economy With Distinction

University of Durham 2013–2017
BA in Politics, Philosophy and Economics First Class Honours
Year abroad at University of Hong Kong

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Themes: Political Communication, Contentious Politics, Public Opinion
Methods: Causal Inference, Text-as-Data, NLP, Measurement

FORTHCOMING PUBLICATIONS

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- Jacobs, Michael. “Do Unpopular Tactics Undermine the Persuasiveness of Protest?” *American Political Science Review* (Conditionally accepted)
 - Jacobs, Michael. “Breaking into the Public Sphere: How Protest Tactics Shape Media Visibility.” *British Journal of Political Science* (Accepted)

WORKING PAPERS

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- Jacobs, Michael. “How Effective are Protests at Shifting Public Discourse in Activists’ Preferred Direction?” Working paper. *Presented at APSA 2024; under review at AJPS*
 - Jacobs, Michael, Colin Henry, Benjamin Guinaudeau, Solomon Messing, Joshua A. Tucker, Karsten Donnay, Fabrizio Gilardi, Dominik Hangartner, Gloria Gennaro. “An Experimental Audit of Content Moderation on TikTok Across Eight Countries.” Working paper. *Presented at APSA 2026*
 - Macmillan-Scott, Olivia, Michael Jacobs, Nils Metternich and Mirco Musolesi. “Framing the Narrative: Ideological Mimicry in Large Language Models.” Working paper. *Submitted to ICLR 2027*

TEACHING

Tutorial Instructor, ETH Zürich, Switzerland 2026
Methods IV: Introduction to Statistical Learning (PG)

Guest Lecturer, University College London, UK 2025
Quantitative Text Analysis for Social Science (UG & PG)
Developed and delivered two 2hr lectures on deep learning language models.

Teaching Assistant, University College London, UK
Democracy and Authoritarianism (UG) 2023
Causal Analysis (Q-step) (UG) 2022, 2024

Teaching Assistant, London School of Economics, UK	2023
Introduction to Data Science and Machine Learning, Summer School (UG & PG)	
Teaching Assistant, King's College London, UK	2021
Principles of Economics (UG)	

OTHER EMPLOYMENT

UCL – Research Assistant	2024
Research Assistant for a project seeking to measure the climate policy positions of political parties in advanced democracies. Tasks involved auditing and improving an analysis pipeline for collecting texts from an API, tokenising into sentences, and preparing for manual labelling.	
UK Treasury – Policy Advisor, Personal Tax, Welfare, Pensions	2020–2021
Policy development in the area of pensions tax. Contributed to the development of tax policy with respect to the remedy for age discrimination in the 2015 public service pension reforms (the McCloud case).	
UK Treasury – Policy Advisor, Enterprise and Growth Unit	2018–2020
Spending control for the Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy (BEIS) with respect to automotive and aerospace sector policy (around £200m p.a.), over the course of two budgets and the 2019 Spending Round.	

CONFERENCES & WORKSHOPS

APSA Annual Meeting, presentation	2024
ECPR General Conference, presentation	2024
Organiser & participant, UCL Conflict & Change PhD Workshop	2023, 2024
Text as Data Reading Group, presentation	2023
Digital Democracy Workshop, University of Zurich, presentation	2023
EPSA Annual Conference, presentation	2023
UCL Conflict & Change PhD Workshop, presentation	2022, 2023

GRADUATE METHODS TRAINING

Advanced Methods for Text as Data, Essex Summer School (unassessed)	2022
Time Series Econometrics, UCL (audited)	2022
Foundations of Machine Learning, UCL (audited)	2021
Qualitative Methods: Case Studies and Comparative Analysis, UCL (73%)	2021
Causal Inference for Observational and Experimental Studies, LSE (88%)	2018
Quantitative Text Analysis, LSE (87%)	2018
Applied Regression Analysis, LSE (89%)	2017

GRANTS & SCHOLARSHIPS

UCL Political Science Departmental Research Fund Grant	2024
To perform survey experiment on persuasive effects of protest. Value: £8,800	
ESRC Doctoral Scholarship (Quantitative Methods Enhancement)	2021–2025
Value: £20,000 p.a.	

AWARDS

UCL PGTA Excellence in Student Feedback Award	2024
LSE Winner of the MSc Political Science and Political Economy Prize	2018
For best overall performance (highest overall grade in the MSc cohort, 85%)	
Durham J.S. Mill Prize	2017
For best performance in the UG PPE cohort	
Durham Award for Best UG Dissertation in Politics Department	2017
Mark of 93% for “Do Voters Trust Politicians that Pander? Policy Platforms as a Signal of Character”	

SOFTWARE

LaTeX (good), R (proficient), R Markdown (proficient), Python (intermediate)